

OPPOSING NARRATIVES
Far left, Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini at a rally in Gurugram, Aug. 10; leader of Opposition Bhupinder Singh Hooda addressing a press conference in Rohtak, Jul. 19

dent its prospects. Even as Opposition leader and former CM Bhupinder Singh Hooda claims that his party is fine with the present schedule, the unexpectedly early election has stirred anxiety within the Congress camp as well. For, both Hooda and Congress national general secretary Kumari Selja are on the warpath, vying for leadership roles in the assembly polls. Selja's influence stems from her proximity to the Gandhis while Hooda has consolidated his position as the pre-eminent Jat leader in the state. The Congress has also yet to reconcile the aspirations of other state leaders like Rajya Sabha member Randeep Singh Surjewala and former minister Captain Ajay Singh Yadav.

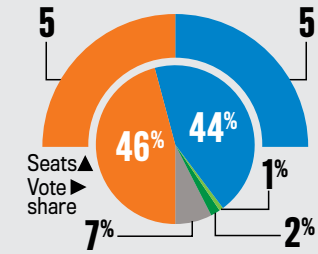
The BJP, too, faces its share of internal challenges. The party is working overtime to appease Union ministers Rao Inderjit Singh and Krishan Pal Gurjar, both of whom are lobbying for their children—Arti Singh Rao and Devinder Gurjar, respectively—to make their political debuts. But the party, say insiders, is considering to field both Union ministers instead, so they can project themselves as CM prospects and enthuse their respective support base of Ahir and Gurjar communities—crucial components of the BJP's non-Jat voter base.

BATTLE RECORD

How the parties have fared in recent polls

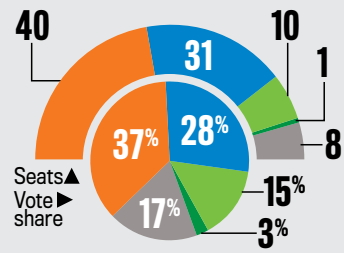
LOK SABHA 2024

Total seats: 10



ASSEMBLY 2019

Total seats: 90



BJP Cong JJP
INLD Others

Vote share figures have been rounded off

While the BJP did make attempts to assuage voter discontent ahead of the Lok Sabha election, addressing issues such as unemployment, inflation and farmer protests, these efforts clearly failed to stop the Congress from breaching the non-Jat caste coalition meticulously crafted by the saffron party over the past decade. According to a Lokniti-CSDS (Centre for the Study of Developing Societies) post-poll survey, the BJP's support among OBCs plummeted from 74 per cent in 2019 to about 44 per cent this year. Meanwhile, the Jats, estimated to constitute about 22 per cent of the electorate and capable of influencing other non-agricultural communities as well, solidly backed the Congress (64 per cent; a massive jump of 31 percentage points).

In response, the Saini government has implemented a series of corrective measures. These include relaxing the norms for obtaining Parivar Pehchan Patra cards (a flagship scheme launched in 2020 that is marred by inaccuracies), amending policies to facilitate the hiring of Agniveers in both public and private sectors after their stint in the armed forces, eliminating age restrictions under the life security scheme for farmers and agricultural labourers, and increasing allowances for educated youths. Interestingly, the BJP's strategy has involved distancing itself from Khattar, removing his images from publicity material and reducing his public appearances. While Khattar is now a Union minister, both Saini and the new state BJP chief, Mohan Lal Badoli, are perceived to be his protégés. This perception was not helping the ruling party mitigate the anti-incumbency sentiment associated with Khattar's tenure.

That said, the assembly election in Haryana has become a direct contest between the BJP and the Congress, as regional forces like the Indian National Lok Dal (INLD) and its offshoot